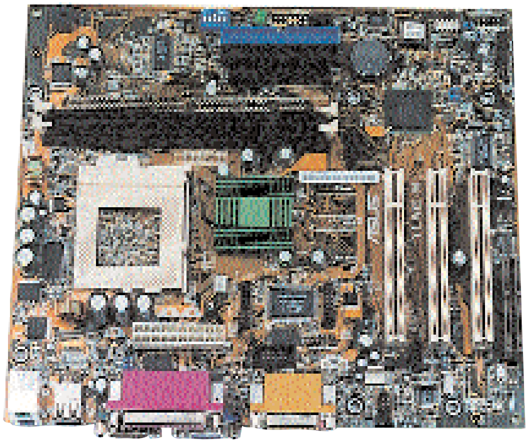

If you prefer the Intel platform, the Mercury KOB 845G-NDSmx would be the best buy due to its low price. If it's sheer performance you want, the MSI 845PE-Max2 would be the right choice.

On the AMD front, the MSI KT Ultra 400 would give you top-notch performance. On the value-for-money plank, the ASUS A7S266 offers reasonably good performance.

Market overview

With technological updates happening at a brisk pace, new and innovative features such as Serial ATA, USB 2.0 and RAID are needed to stay ahead of the competition.

AOpen has, for instance, added FM Radio on its motherboard, making it a complete entertainment machine. Another trend is the shrinking size—the latest entrant from VIA is almost half the size of its competitors, but offers comparable performance.

The major players in terms of volume are Mercury, Digi-Link, DFI, Krypton and HIS. Brands such as MSI and ASUS, which are priced slightly on the higher side, are preferred more by technology enthusiasts and users looking in for performance. Since P4 processors sell the most, P4-compliant motherboards are more in demand. Motherboards supporting Celeron and PIII are also available in the market, but there are few takers. Entry-level boards for both AMD and Intel are available in the range of Rs 3,500 to Rs 3,800, and with processor prices falling in the future, even motherboards may see a plunge in prices to the tune of 5 to 8 per cent in the mid-range and premium segments.

With market demand also gaining momentum in smaller cities and towns, the focus is on low-cost PCs, and vendors offering real value for money are the ones who stand to gain. The demand for high-end motherboards, once concentrated in metros, has now moved to B and C class cities all over India.

Recently, some new brands have become available in small pockets of India. Prominent among these are Jetway, Proteam, Epox and AOpen. These new entrants are focusing on the value segment, with various chipsets. When talking about the most popular chipset, Intel's 845G supporting SDRAM memory is hot, followed by others such as 845E for DDR. SiS, with its 650 chipset, is the one of the front-runners in this transitional phase, supporting both SDRAM to DDR. With its low cost of around Rs 4,000, this is indeed a great buy.

Another important—and very recent—trend is that DDR memory is fast replacing SDRAM. In the near future, DDR RAM will become an entry-level feature, rendering SDRAM obsolete.

Buying Tips

■ To get the best deal, always poke around a few shops before you make the final decision. This will give you a fair idea of what's currently available in the market. The best way to buy the ideal board is to first read reviews and then look around for either the same board or its nearest variant in the market.

■ A motherboard may present itself in various guises. The MSI 845 MAX2, for example, is available in Pure, FIR and FISR variants. Pure is the base model, and the others have certain feature additions such as RAID and USB 2.0, but for minimal increments in price. Don't buy the costliest board if you think you will never use the additional features. Buying extra features means additional maintenance of drivers and ports.

■ If you're a hardcore gamer or a fan of overclocking, check that the space around the CPU is spacious enough for you to install a larger heatsink-fan combination to keep things cool. Go in for a board that allows overclocking of FSB in steps of 1 MHz, and allows core voltage adjustment.

■ While buying a motherboard, ensure that its chipset supports both, the speed of your processor and the speed of the Front Side Bus (FSB). This is very critical today, where many boards available in the market might not support the clock speed of your processor. Even if it does, it may not support your CPU's fast FSB and underclock it, lowering the performance.

■ With your applications in mind, ensure that your motherboard is sufficiently feature-rich. In particular, make sure it has enough PCI and memory slots for future expansion.

■ If cost is not a hindrance, opt for a motherboard that has both an onboard video chipset and an AGP slot. This will give you greater flexibility while making future upgrades. Also check whether the AGP slot supports the latest 8X transfer rate. Many new cards now support AGP8X and future cards will run on this.

■ Ensure that your motherboard has an onboard sound chipset (and, if you so require, integrated Ethernet). Newer boards also support 5.2 channel Dolby Digital and Gigabit Ethernet, which have started showing up on some high-end boards targeted at desktop users.

■ While buying a motherboard, check whether the board supports the type of memory your system has—buyers of DDR-SDRAM should be especially careful in this regard.